

PHILOSOPHY OF FIP PROGRAM

FIP

The department goal is to assist families towards self-sufficiency. Self-sufficiency is best accomplished by:

- Adults being employed,
- Securing court-ordered child support for each child where appropriate,
- Providing life skills training for those needing it including minor and teen parents, and
- Ensuring that all children have access to medical care.

As families become self-sufficient, we will meet the legal mandates such as work participation rates, reducing subsequent out of wedlock pregnancies, ensuring that teens are completing secondary education, and ensuring that minor parents are living in appropriate settings.

Role of the FIS

The Family Independence Specialist (FIS) uses a Strength Based Solution Focused Approach and will:

- Identify goals with the client and develop plans for self-sufficiency, expressed in the client's own words, when possible. This will occur through the interactive solution focused process. When setting goals with the client, keep in mind that the goals should be clear, simple, specific, measurable, realistic, positive and important to the client. Clients must see their role in these goals for themselves to change concrete behavior. Monitor progress toward meeting the goals identified in the Family Self Sufficiency Plan (FSSP).
- Modify or add to the plan, when there is a change in circumstances; or upon discovery of a challenge or concern.
- Determine eligibility for financial and medical programs.
- Identify and or authorize support services to help families carry out their plan.

- Provide direct services such as counseling and problem solving when needed. This is especially helpful for clients who are in noncompliance.
- Identify resources and initiate referrals for community services, including employment and training, and domestic violence counseling.
- Explore options and authorize child care.

Case managers should focus on building a trusting relationship with families using the solution-focused interviewing skills. This is best accomplished by doing an interview. Building trust requires accepting clients for who they are, and understanding they are key in identifying their own needs and strengths in moving toward self-sufficiency. Case managers will help clients discover their needs and build on their strengths, recognizing that open and frequent communication is necessary to build the family's trust.

Use all available means in facilitating communications and trust. Such contact and communication are effective in developing and monitoring plans/contracts while reducing negative consequences. However, consequences will be used to reinforce the concept that clients are responsible for their own lives. Whenever possible, discretion has been left to staff to work with families. Discretion includes the frequency and types of contact beyond mandatory client contacts.

As the relationship with the client begins to build, the client may begin to disclose other barriers to self-sufficiency, such as domestic violence. The Michigan Department of Health and Human Services (MDHHS) believes all individuals have a right to be safe from violence. Domestic violence is a critical issue for many people. Victims of domestic violence need services that enhance their safety and self-sufficiency.

If there is a disclosure of domestic violence, and the client is not receiving services, the FIS must refer the family to the appropriate community services. Determine if domestic violence presents a barrier to cooperation with agency requirements, such as pursuit of child support (BEM 255), participation in employment and training activities (BEM 230A), and third-party liability (BEM 257).

Interviews

Interviews provide the best opportunity to interact with a client. Interviews help establish a trusting relationship which will open the door to an increased level of participation and willingness to discuss the family concerns.

While doing the interview, you can celebrate successes and identify challenges the family faces. Review and monitor the FSSP goals and activities and help the clients make a plan for removing any obstacles they perceive.

Topics for Discussion

When talking with a client, there are numerous topics for you to discuss, such as:

- The successes each adult has had since the previous contact for example, a plan for employment and, if they are employed, what progress have they made toward a raise, promotion, increased hours, or the results of any evaluations? This discussion will also give you an opportunity to make sure the correct earned income is in the benefit budgets.
- Any concerns or challenges that have come up which slowed down or hindered the family's movement to self-sufficiency. To meet those challenges, develop a plan. Compliment the family on any successes they had in dealing with the challenges or concerns. If a challenge or concern continues to exist, discuss and create a plan using the Solution Focused Approach to help the family meet these challenges.
- Discuss goals that the adults have for themselves which they believe will lead to self-sufficiency, what steps they need to take to achieve these goals, and how confident and motivated they are in achieving these goals (scaling questions).
- Involve the family in a discussion of the children and the importance of education. Ask the adult and the children, if present, how each child is doing in school, what their interests are and what extra-curricular activities they are participating in. Together with the family, talk about resources or opportunities for the children in their areas of interest.

This discussion will provide an opportunity for you to provide positive feedback and compliments. It will increase participation and involve the entire family in the plan to support each other. Inform them of the Tuition Incentive Program and other educational opportunities that are available for children to attend college if applicable.

- Ask what personal and community resources they know of that may be available to help the family remove their challenges and concerns, meet their goals, and move toward self-sufficiency. If the client does not know about community resources, help them develop a plan that will teach them to find these resources.
- Discuss child care arrangements that the parent has made for care of the children while the parent is employed, child care arrangements during school breaks, and back-up plans for child care if the provider is ill or otherwise unable to care for the children.
- Explain the Federal Earned Income Tax Credit and how receiving this credit throughout the year can increase monthly income. Help them find out how to apply for the credit.
- Discuss how to access the advanced education and training opportunities that are available for persons meeting the participation requirements.
- Discuss support services that are available while persons are participating in employment-related activities.
- Discuss the children and their adjustment to having the parent employed or otherwise out of the home and participating in employment-related activities.
- The children and their relationship to a stepparent or other adult living in the home can also be a topic of discussion and planning with the parent.
- Let clients know there are family and/or community support groups that are available in cases of emergencies.

For ineligible grantee cases, the focus of the interview should be a discussion about the children and resources that may be available to the family and/or the ineligible grantee, for example,

support groups that are available to grandparents who are raising grandchildren.

In absent parent situations, discuss the importance of parenting time and the involvement of both parents in a child's life. Discuss the relationship between the absent parent and child. Include steps in the plan to make it better. This discussion is also important for ineligible grantee cases. Does the child visit the parent? Are there custody issues? Is the relative interested in securing guardianship of the child, if appropriate?

In all interviews, including ineligible grantee situations, be alert to key indicators that signal problems in the home which may indicate a need for preventive services or require intervention by protective services. Be alert to situations of domestic violence, substance abuse by any family member, and behavioral problems of children or conflicts between family members.

Ask for the client's explanation of events but if you believe that the home environment requires preventive or protective services involvement, a referral must be made.